

The couple started to bleed money. One day, Katrina couldn't buy groceries because the credit card had been maxed out. She tried the debit card and it, too, was declined. She drove home in a daze, her kids screaming in the back seat. When she arrived home, she went to the family computer and tried to log into the bank account she shared with Raj. Then she realized she didn't know the password. She had never needed it before because her husband handled all of their accounts. Katrina had no relationship whatsoever with their financial institution. And because Raj had never let her go with him to see their CPA or financial advisor, she didn't even know their names.

"But that wasn't the worst thing, Kevin," she told me, her face grave. "For as long as we have been married, we have filed a joint tax return. It has been over a decade since I made my own income, but I always signed my name to the return. This year, Raj was found to owe \$45,000 in back taxes. Every piece of furniture we own, our car, our home—it was all purchased with Raj's income. That means they can take it all away from us. And I am liable as well."

I wanted to tell Katrina that her husband's bad money management wouldn't affect her. But unfortunately, I could not. She was right: both Raj *and* Katrina were on the hook for \$45,000. The Canada Revenue Agency could go after them however they pleased. And when money owed to the CRA went into collections, I knew what would happen: they'd stop at nothing to get it. They might freeze the couple's bank accounts, seize the car or the house, or even harass Katrina with phone calls and visits while her husband was at work.

What was Katrina's crucial mistake? You might say "marrying Raj," and I wouldn't argue with you. But really, this wasn't the main mistake. Enough due diligence had been done by Katrina and her family to investigate Raj's financial past; it was his future that had become the problem. Katrina's mistake came after she was married. She allowed herself to become disenfranchised from the family dynasty and from knowledge of the family coffers. She let Raj make every single decision pertaining to money, and unfortunately for their whole family, he made some lousy ones.